The missionaries organised schools for the socially and economically deprived and pleaded for their economic improvement through employment in the state service. They also fought for their 'civil rights' that included access to public roads, and permission for the women of these groups to wear upper garments.

The missionaries gave shelter to orphaned children and other destitute widows in their missions and provided education for them in their boarding schools. Particularly after the famines which were quite common during the nineteenth century, about which we discussed in the previous lesson, the missionaries organized relief. Providing shelter and succour gave these an opportunity to convert people to Christianity. In Tirunelveli district many villages took to Christianity during famines, especially in the last quarter of nineteenth century. The same phenomenon was witnessed in Andhra where Malas and Madigas embraced Christianity in a big way.

The Company government did little to provide modern education for the native population. For a long time, the provision of elementary school facilities to the native population, especially in the interiors for the disprivileged and the poor people, was a responsibility willingly accepted by the Christian missionaries. It must be noted that the Christian Missionaries took the intiative of establishing Hospitals and Dispensaries.

19.8 Significance of the Reform Movements

The orthodox sections of the society could not accept the scientific and ideological onslaught of the socio-religious reformers. As a result of this, the reformers were subjected to abuse, persecution, issuing of fatwas and even assassination attempts by the reactionaries. However, in spite of opposition, these movements contributed towards liberation of the individual from the conformity born out of fear. The translation of religious texts into vernacular languages, emphasis on an individual's right to interpret the scriptures, and simplification of rituals made worship a more personal experience. The movements emphasised the human intellect's capacity to reason and think. By weeding out corrupt elements in religious practices, the reformers enabled their followers to counter the official taunt that their religions and society were decadent and inferior. It gave the rising middle classes the much needed cultural roots to cling to.

SUMMARY

- The role played by Rammohan Roy, and Keshab Chandra Sen in Brahmo Samaj are discussed.
- Arya Samaj established by Dayananda Saraswati, and the Ramakrishna Mission founded by Swami Vivekananda are dealt with.
- Aligarh, Ahmadiya, and Deoband movements for reforming Islamic community are explained.
- Parsi, Sikh reform movements as well as the work of Theosophical society are described.
- Services rendered by Christian missionaries are analysed.
- The social reform movements represented by Jyotiba Phule, Pandita Ramabai and Narayana Guru and by Ramalinga Adigaland Iyotheethoss Pandithar in Tamilnadu are highlighted.

EXERCISE

R4I4V2

I. Choose the correct answer

1. _____ was the first province, where several ideas of reforms originated.

   (a) Punjab (b) Bengal (c) Bombay (d) Madras

2. "The Father of Indian Renaissance" was ____.

   (a) Swami Vivekananda

   (b) Dayananda Saraswathi

   (c) Raja Rammohan Roy

   (d) Atmaram Pandurang

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